

Figure 12: K. Chidambaranatha Mudaliar

K. Chidambaranatha Mudaliar (Figure 12), was a landlord from Sirkazhi in the fertile Kaveri basin. A biography published on the occasion of his sixtieth birthday refers to him as a product of 'the intense national awakening at the turn of the century' but curiously makes no mention of his contribution to SSNCo. A champion of indigenous weaving who always wore Swadeshi cloth, he had also raised contributions for the National Fund collected by G. Subramania Iyer for the development of cottage industries. A patron of Saiva Siddhanta Sabhai and a member of the Theosophical Society, he later became a member of the Madras Legislature.[19]

Despite the hostility of an overwhelming number of the new directors, VOC was not without friends. Apart from Pandithurai Thevar, the president of the company, S.T.A. Arumugam Pillai, A.M.M. Arunachalam Pillai, S.S.V. Krishna Pillai and C. Vijayaraghavachari were far from antagonistic towards him. As we shall see in a later chapter, they remained in touch with VOC even after his conviction for sedition, offering some reassurance if not assistance. Considering that T.S. Subramania Pillai contributed to both the Coral Mills workers' strike fund and VOC's defence fund, we may include him in this group as well.[20] But these half-a-dozen or so directors were outnumbered in a board of over thirty.